There had been a few encounters in the past twelve hours. As a result of that the gang broke up into smaller groups and tried to get away through the dense foliage. As we were more familiar with the area, our battalion was given the task of combing the dense jungles. Therefore most of our officers and men were tasked to search the jungles as subunits or special mission patrols. Additional units were moved into this sector and deployed on the ridgelines. They became the anvil and we acted as the hammer. This was to ensure that we captured the whole gang. We did our best to ensure that none of them was able to escape from the dragnet. Since the insurgents were not giving a fight, while fleeing they ran into the ambushes along the ridgelines, and the troops deployed there captured them and took the credit. But the real slogging was being done by us.

In one encounter, we had killed some of them but we lost one soldier. The first insurgent we caught was quickly brought to the Battalion HQ. As the officiating adjutant, I was the one who did the preliminary interrogation. The insurgent, a Sema lad who looked barely in his teens, was carrying a sack that weighed no less than 30 kilograms, and had been walking for days on end. When I saw the arms and munitions he was carrying, I was shocked. It could have been a metal pack. Surprisingly, there was a small red-coloured pocketbook dedicated to Mao Tse-tung in the pack. There were no rations, only some brown gooey stuff which I was told was opium. No wonder he was famished and fatigued. So the first thing I ordered was a mug of tea and some food for this poor boy, which he devoured as fast as he could. He recounted his story of how he left his village in December 1967 and walked all the way to Myitkyina in Burma, with the rest of the gang. From there they went by road to a place near Kunming in Yunan province of China. There was a training camp where they were given training for a few months. When they first reached there, as recalled by this insurgent, they were asked to pray to their God for providing them with food. So they remained hungry. Only when they praised Mao Tse-tung was food served to them.